

Africanization or Africanisation (lit., making something African) has been applied in various contexts, notably in geographic and personal naming and in the composition of the civil service via processes such as indigenization.

Africanization of names

Africanization has referred to the modification of place, names and personal names to reflect an "African" identity. In some cases, changes are not only of transliteration but of the European name.

In many cases during the colonial period, African placenames were Anglicized or Francized.

Place names

Country names

A number of African countries have undergone name changes during the previous century as the result of consolidations and secessions, territories gaining sovereignty, and regime changes.

Other place names

Fernando Po island changed to Bioko Island

Léopoldville changed to Kinshasa

Salisbury changed to Harare

Lourenço Marques changed to Maputo

Nova Lisboa changed to Huambo

Fort Lamy changed to N'Djaména

Tananarive changed to Antananarivo

Bathurst changed to Banjul

Santa Isabel/Port Clarence changed to Malabo

Élisabethville changed to Lubumbashi

Stanleyville changed to Kisangani

Luluabourg changed to Kananga

Ponthierville changed to Ubundu

Novo Redondo changed to Sumbe

Moçâmedes changed to Namibe, but changed back to Moçâmedes in 2016

Abercorn changed to Mbala

Broken Hill changed to Kabwe

Fort Jameson changed to Chipata

Hartley changed to Chegutu

Fort Victoria changed to Masvingo

Many places whose names were of European origin in South Africa have undergone Africanization since 1994; see South African Geographical Names Council.

Since July 2025, all 17 administrative regions of Burkina Faso have had their French names replaced with names that reflect the country's new official and national languages.

Port Elizabeth changed to Gqeberha in 2021.

Personal names

Joseph-Désiré Mobutu changed to Mobutu Sese Seko

François Tombalbaye changed to N'Garta Tombalbaye

Étienne Eyadéma changed to Gnassingbé Eyadéma

Francisco Macías Nguema changed to Masie Nguema Biyogo N'Gue Ndong

Sometimes, the name change can be used to reflect a change of faith, most prominently seen in the case of Islam. (See Islamic name.)

Examples:

Albert-Bernard Bongo changed to Omar Bongo

Dawda Jawara changed to David Jawara in 1953

Jean-Bédel Bokassa changed to Salah Eddine Ahmed Bokassa

Africanization of civil services

In some countries after following their independence, "Africanization" was the name given to racial policies and affirmative action, which were intended to increase the number of indigenous Africans in the civil service.

Localization in African languages

The term Africanization, abbreviated as the numeronym "A12n," has been applied to discussion of internationalization and localization of software and content in African languages.

See also

List of renamed places in South Africa

List of city name changes

List of renamed places in Namibia

List of renamed places in Zimbabwe

List of renamed places in the Democratic Republic of the Congo

== References ==